

Practicing Difficult Conversations with AI

AI role-play gives managers a safe, private space to rehearse before the real moment arrives — building confidence, refining language, and preparing for resistance.



Practice First

Rehearse before real conversations



Test Wording

Refine how you say it



Prepare for Pushback

Anticipate resistance



Build Confidence

Improve with every attempt



Receive Feedback

Get coaching after each session



Try Again Safely

No real stakes, real learning



Practice makes the real conversation better. Every rehearsal reduces anxiety and sharpens your approach.

Role-Play Prompt — Defensive Employee

Use this prompt to simulate a challenging conversation with an employee who missed deadlines and responds with emotional pushback. The AI will hold its ground — and then coach you.

AI Prompt: "Act as a defensive employee who missed several deadlines. I am your manager. Push back respectfully but emotionally. Do not make the conversation easy. After 6 exchanges, switch to coaching observer and evaluate my performance."

After 6 exchanges, the AI evaluates you across five dimensions:

1

Clarity

Were your expectations clearly communicated?

2

Empathy

Did you acknowledge the employee's perspective?

3

Listening

Did you pause and respond to what was said?

4

Accountability

Did you hold the standard without attacking?

5

Follow-Up

Did you close with clear next steps?

Role-Play Prompt

Hesitant Employee

This scenario trains managers to create psychological safety — drawing out an employee who is afraid to speak honestly.

📌 **Key challenge:** The employee only opens up if you ask the right questions with the right tone.

AI Prompt: "Act as a hesitant employee who is unsure whether it is safe to speak honestly. I am your manager. Be cautious at first. If I ask supportive open-ended questions, gradually share more. After 6 exchanges, give feedback on my tone, listening, and questions."

What the AI evaluates after the session:

→ Tone

Did your language feel safe and non-threatening?

→ Listening

Did you reflect back what the employee shared?

→ Questions

Were your questions open-ended and genuinely curious?



Role-Play Prompt — Disengaged Employee

This scenario challenges managers to stay patient and curious when an employee gives minimal responses and seems emotionally checked out. The real reason only emerges if you ask the right questions.

AI Prompt: "Act as a disengaged employee who gives short answers and seems checked out. I am your manager. Do not reveal the full reason immediately. If I ask thoughtful questions, share more context. After 6 exchanges, evaluate my patience, curiosity, and next steps."

Patience

Did you resist filling silence or rushing to conclusions?

Curiosity

Did you dig deeper rather than accept surface answers?

Next Steps

Did you leave the conversation with a clear path forward?

AI as Coaching Observer

After completing a practice conversation, use AI to step back and evaluate your performance objectively. Paste an anonymized transcript or coaching plan and let the AI act as your personal coaching observer.

AI Prompt: "Act as a coaching observer. Review this anonymized coaching plan or transcript: [insert]. Evaluate the following dimensions, then give me 2 strengths, 2 improvements, and a stronger closing statement."

01

Purpose

Was the goal of the conversation clear?

02

Listening

Did you demonstrate active listening?

03

Questions

Were questions open and coaching-oriented?

04

Feedback Clarity

Was feedback specific and actionable?

05

Empathy

Did you acknowledge feelings and context?

06

Accountability

Were standards upheld with respect?

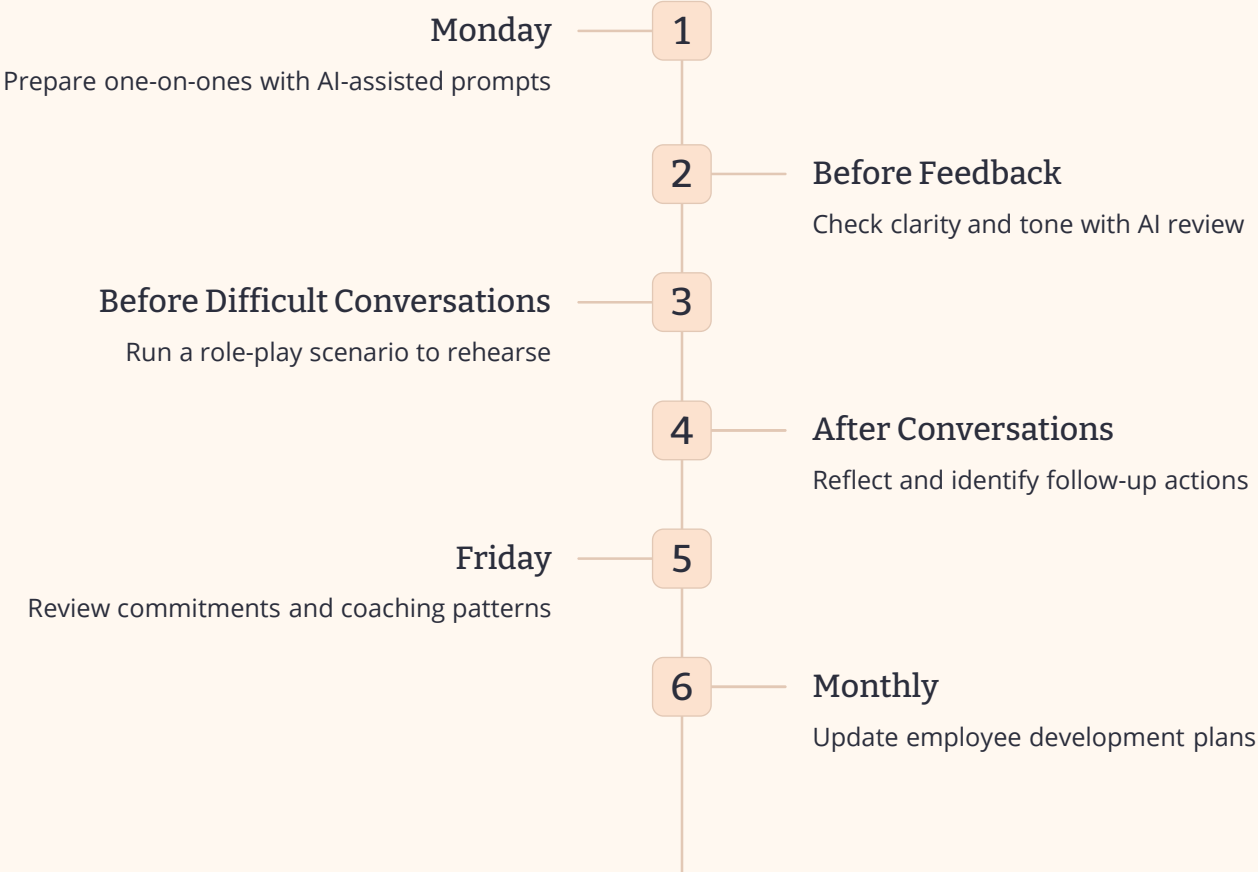
07

Follow-Up

Were next steps defined and owned?

Repeatable Weekly AI Coaching Workflow

Build AI-assisted coaching into your weekly rhythm. This workflow ensures you are always prepared, reflective, and improving — without adding significant time to your schedule.



 Consistency is the key. A few minutes of AI-assisted preparation each day compounds into significantly stronger coaching over time.

Post-Conversation Reflection Prompt

Use this prompt after any coaching conversation — real or practice — to extract learning and plan your next move.

📌 Always anonymize before pasting any conversation details into AI tools.

AI Prompt: "Act as a coaching reflection partner. Conversation summary: [anonymized summary]. My goal was: [insert]. What happened: [insert]."

The AI will provide structured reflection across six areas:

- 1 What I Handled Well
- 2 Missed Coaching Opportunities
- 3 Clarity of Next Steps
- 4 Follow-Up Actions
- 5 One Thing to Improve
- 6 A Short Follow-Up Message

Final Project — AI Coaching Teammate Toolkit

Your final project is to build a personalized AI Coaching Teammate Toolkit — a complete, reusable resource that reflects your coaching philosophy and integrates AI at every stage of the coaching cycle.

1

Coaching Philosophy

Your personal statement of purpose as a coach

2

One-on-One Prep Prompt

AI prompt for preparing weekly check-ins

3

Feedback Prompt

AI prompt for drafting clear, empathetic feedback

4

Development Planning Prompt

AI prompt for building employee growth plans

5

Role-Play Prompt

Difficult conversation rehearsal scenario

6

Reflection Prompt

Post-conversation learning and follow-up

7

Weekly Workflow

Your repeatable AI-assisted coaching rhythm

8

Ethical Use Checklist

Guardrails for responsible AI use

9

Success Measures

How you will know your coaching is working

Coaching Philosophy Template

Your coaching philosophy is the foundation of your toolkit. It defines what you believe about your role — and where AI fits within it. Complete the statement below and make it your own.

"My coaching role is to help employees **understand expectations, build confidence, strengthen performance, and take ownership of growth.**

I will use AI to **prepare, practice, and reflect** — but I will keep **empathy, judgment, trust, and accountability** as my responsibility."

AI's Role

Prepare · Practice · Reflect · Draft · Analyze

Your Role

Empathy · Judgment · Trust · Accountability · Relationship

 The most effective coaching happens when human wisdom and AI capability work together — each doing what it does best.



Ethical Use Checklist

Before using AI in any coaching context, run through this checklist. Responsible use protects your employees, your organization, and your integrity as a leader.

Privacy Protected

I removed all private employee details before using AI

HR Boundaries Respected

I avoided entering sensitive HR or legal information

Bias Reviewed

I checked the AI output for potential bias or unfair framing

Accuracy Verified

I confirmed the content is factually accurate and appropriate

Humanized

I adapted the wording so it sounds like me, not a machine

Policy Compliant

I followed my organization's AI and data use policies

Final Decision Mine

I made the final judgment call — AI only informed it



Never paste identifiable employee information into any AI tool.
Always anonymize first.

Course Success Check

You have completed the course. You are ready to lead with AI as your coaching teammate. Use this checklist to confirm your readiness — and return to it whenever you want to measure your growth.



Prepare Conversations

Use AI to prepare for coaching conversations with clarity and purpose



Ask Stronger Questions

Generate open-ended, coaching-quality questions with AI support



Draft Clearer Feedback

Use AI to write specific, balanced, and actionable feedback



Recognize Performance

Craft meaningful recognition that motivates and reinforces growth



Build Development Plans

Co-create employee growth plans that are realistic and inspiring



Practice Difficult Conversations

Rehearse challenging scenarios safely before the real moment



Reflect After Coaching

Extract learning from every conversation to continuously improve



Identify Follow-Up Actions

Close every conversation with clear, owned next steps



Improve Team Performance

Build a coaching culture that drives sustained team growth over time



You are ready. AI does not replace your coaching — it amplifies it. Lead with empathy, prepare with AI, and keep growing.